Kate Bernola

Design leader

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I build practices that didn't exist, get them adopted across organizations, and leave teams permanently more capable than I found them.

SKILLS

- AI product design
- Design system adoption
- Hiring and talent development
- Change management
- Governance
- A/B testing
- Content design
- Accessibility (WCAG)
- Knowledge management

AWARDS

Top HR Product
2026, WISE
HR Executive

Brandon Hall gold
2022, Paychex Voice Assist
Best advance in AI for business impact

Silver Stevie
2021, PPP Loan Forgiveness Estimator

My work contributed to these industry awards, plus 28 others.

EXPERIENCE

Paychex — 2019 – 2026

UX Design Manager, Product Design and Head of Multimedia — 2024 – 2026

RAISING THE BAR

- Managed a team of 13 designers and 2 researchers across 4 product areas: Tax, Payments, the accountant platform and its design system, and multimedia.
- Coached an IC to lead a volunteer design team that built our promotional toolkit and introduced micro-animations to the company. Every treatment beat the control. Made $7M, 1.9x the prior year and 22% over goal.
- Turned a request for another in-app promotion into a navigation fix. A free test lifted visits 3.4x. The business stopped asking for one-off promotions and put the new navigation on the roadmap. Details
- Reframed a request to add AI sparkles into a visual identity for all smart features. My designer's owl-based direction became WISE, our AI brand, and gave Paychex a distinctive, ownable look.

INFLUENCING DECISIONS

- Built customer journeys for tax registration and payments. Exposed major pain points. Won funding to fix them, standing up a new portfolio with a dozen dev teams.
- Secured earlier UX involvement in roadmap planning. Guided the build of a Claude-based AI agent that compressed 6 weeks of discovery into 8 days.
- Convinced an exec to test telling admins we advertised paid benefits to employees, a fact hidden for fear they'd restrict access to the offer. Under 2% opted out; instead, admins promoted the offer, and employee visits rose 6.8x. This became the standard.

SOLVING THE RIGHT PROBLEM

- Designed an A/B test for W-2 access, the year's top call driver. Used Heap to identify where users searched. Added banners that increased task success from 42% to 82% and cut search time from 2:03 to 39 seconds.
- Inherited a multimedia team spending half its time on videos that mirrored Help articles. Found 95% would never justify the cost, and stopped the work. Freed $150K a year across the company. Details
- Closed a 15-point UMUX usability gap on a new AI dashboard. Saw past early adopters' "you didn't warn me!" complaints to the root cause: a new panel pushed familiar UI below the fold. Shortened it before general rollout.
- Personally redesigned the data-sharing consent workflow for our client referral program. Used interaction design, visual cues, and plain language to clarify intent. Consent rose from 12% to 46%.

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TOOLS

Figma
Figma Make
ZeroHeight
Claude
Microsoft Copilot
Pendo
Heap (web analytics)
Miro
Jira
Confluence

EDUCATION

University of Notre Dame
BBA, Marketing & Psychology
Magna cum laude, 3.7 GPA
Varsity letters, football & rowing

EXPERIENCE continued

UX Design Manager, Head of Content Design — 2021 – 2024

BUILDING THE PRACTICE

- Built a content design practice from scratch, growing from 1 employee to 12. Together they supported 40+ product designers across 100+ dev teams.
- Hired 11 people and personally trained 9 with no prior content design experience, including 2 internal hires. Achieved 75% promotion rate and 92% retention.
- After 2.5 years, decentralized the content design team from a shared service to designers embedded in their products. Positioned a senior content designer to lead the community of practice.

ESTABLISHING GOVERNANCE

- Moved in-app marketing from prohibited to permitted. Founded a governance board to ensure oversight from support, marketing, and Product. Set guardrails and proposed alternatives to asks that put client relationships at risk.
- Flagged the risk when a cross-sell campaign threatened platform IA. Designed alternatives, proved 2x click-through with an A/B test, and set exposure limits. Campaign generated 148 wins and $500K in recurring revenue.
- Rolled out frameworks for change management, feature awareness, and selling to 100 UX practitioners across 25+ products. Distinguished change management vs. feature awareness in one question: can the user still do the task the way they did before?
- Defined Paychex Assistant's knowledge-management model: inclusion criteria, taxonomy, content structure, and success metrics. In its first rollout, usage tripled, questions resolved without a rep rose from 55% to 75%, and case volume fell 6%.

UX Design Operations Specialist — 2020 – 2021

- Burned down a 6-month content backlog in 2 months by reorganizing the work and cutting low-value requests.

UX Content Designer — 2019 – 2020

- Owned design and content for the company's top priority during COVID: the PPP Loan Forgiveness Estimator, a financial services tool that helped 500K small businesses get $65B in funding.

Xerox Corporation — 2008 – 2018

Six roles, most recently **Corporate Communications Manager, Intranet UX**.

- Led UX and product management for two Fortune 500 intranets. Defined IA and governance, directed designers and writers, and cut $125K a year in overhead.
- Owned and ran change management for the Xerox and Conduent separation: 140,000 employees across 180 countries.
- Managed a $1M budget for Xerox's 2015 Leadership Meeting, a three-day event for 200 executives.